

FREE RESOURCE · LEADERSHIP

Leadership Self-Assessment

A 20-question self-assessment across four leadership competencies — Communication, Decision-Making, Team Development, and Strategic Thinking. Includes a scoring guide and structured reflection prompts.

- 20 Questions
- 4 Competencies
- Scoring Guide
- Reflection Guide

20 questions	4 competencies	100 max score	Reflection guide
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BEFORE YOU START

Rate yourself on how consistently you demonstrate each behaviour — not how you would like to behave, or how you behaved once in a good situation. Use the 1–5 scale: **1 = Rarely or never**, **2 = Sometimes**, **3 = Usually**, **4 = Often**, **5 = Consistently / always**. Complete all 20 questions before moving to the scoring guide. Allow 20–30 minutes without interruption.

Competency 1 — Communication

Questions 1–5 · Max 25 points

Effective leaders communicate with clarity, adapt their style to their audience, and create the conditions for honest dialogue. These questions assess how consistently you practise the behaviours that build communication trust.

1

I give people my full attention when they are speaking to me, without interrupting or preparing my response while they talk.

Consider: in meetings, 1:1s, and informal conversations. How present are you, really?

Circle your rating for this question

1

2

3

4

5

Rarely / never

Consistently / always

2

I adapt my communication style depending on who I am speaking to — adjusting my level of detail, tone, and vocabulary for different audiences.

Consider: how you brief a board member versus how you brief a new graduate. Do you adjust, or do you default to one style?

Circle your rating for this question

1

2

3

4

5

Rarely / never

Consistently / always

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3

I deliver difficult feedback clearly and promptly, without softening it to the point where the message is lost.

Consider: think of the last piece of difficult feedback you gave. Was the recipient in no doubt about what needed to change?

Circle your rating for this question



Rarely / never

Consistently / always

4

I actively create space for others to disagree with me or challenge my thinking in meetings.

Consider: do people in your team feel safe to say 'I think you're wrong about this'? Would they tell you if they didn't?

Circle your rating for this question



Rarely / never

Consistently / always

5

I follow up important verbal agreements in writing, so there is no ambiguity about what was decided and what is expected.

Consider: do you rely on people remembering conversations, or do you document what matters?

Circle your rating for this question



Rarely / never

Consistently / always

Competency 2 — Decision-Making

Questions 6–10 · Max 25 points

Strong decision-making is not about always being right — it is about making timely, well-reasoned decisions with the information available, and owning the outcome. These questions assess your decision-making discipline.

6

I make decisions within an appropriate timeframe, without waiting for more certainty than the situation requires.

Consider: are there decisions sitting on your desk right now that you have been avoiding? What are you waiting for?

Circle your rating for this question



Rarely / never

Consistently / always

7

I clearly communicate the rationale behind my decisions, even when I do not need to justify them.

Consider: when you make a call that affects your team, do they understand why — or do they just receive the outcome?

Circle your rating for this question



Rarely / never

Consistently / always

8

I actively seek out perspectives that challenge my initial view before making significant decisions.

Consider: who in your team or network is most likely to disagree with you? Do you seek them out before you decide?

Circle your rating for this question



Rarely / never

Consistently / always

9

I take responsibility for my decisions when they do not produce the intended outcome, without deflecting blame.

Consider: think of a decision in the last 12 months that did not go as planned. How did you respond publicly?

Circle your rating for this question



Rarely / never

Consistently / always

10

I distinguish clearly between decisions that are mine to make and those that need to involve others or be escalated.

Consider: do you over-involve people in decisions you should own, or under-involve them in decisions that affect them?

Circle your rating for this question



Rarely / never

Consistently / always

Competency 3 — Team Development

Questions 11–15 · Max 25 points

The most enduring measure of a leader's effectiveness is the capability they leave behind — not what they achieved personally. These questions assess how deliberately you invest in the people around you.

11

I invest time in understanding each team member's individual strengths, development areas, and career aspirations.

Consider: for each direct report, could you describe what they are working on developing and what they want to achieve in the next two years?

Circle your rating for this question



Rarely / never

Consistently / always

12

I delegate meaningfully — assigning work that stretches people, not just tasks I do not want to do myself.

Consider: is your delegation driven by what develops the person, or by what is most convenient for you?

Circle your rating for this question



Rarely / never

Consistently / always

13

I give regular, specific, behavioural feedback — not just at formal review points.

Consider: when did you last give a piece of informal developmental feedback that named a specific behaviour and its impact?

Circle your rating for this question



Rarely / never

Consistently / always

14

I recognise and acknowledge good work promptly and specifically, naming what was done well and why it mattered.

Consider: generic praise ("well done") has limited impact. Do your team members know specifically what they do that you value?

Circle your rating for this question



Rarely / never

Consistently / always

15

I take active steps to create an environment where team members feel psychologically safe to take risks and make mistakes.

Consider: when someone in your team makes a mistake, what do they experience? Does it make them more or less likely to flag problems early next time?

Circle your rating for this question

1

2

3

4

5

Rarely / never

Consistently / always

Competency 4 — Strategic Thinking

Questions 16–20 · Max 25 points

Strategic thinking is the ability to see beyond the immediate task, connect your work to the broader context, and make choices that position your team and organisation for the future. These questions assess your strategic orientation.

16

I regularly step back from operational detail to think about whether the direction of my team's work is still aligned with the broader organisational strategy.

Consider: when did you last deliberately carve out time to think about direction rather than delivery?

Circle your rating for this question

1 2 3 4 5

Rarely / never

Consistently / always

17

I anticipate how changes in the external environment — market, technology, regulation, or people — might affect my team or organisation.

Consider: what external trend is most likely to disrupt your area of work in the next three years? Do you have a view on it?

Circle your rating for this question

1 2 3 4 5

Rarely / never

Consistently / always

18

I make prioritisation decisions explicitly, saying no to work that does not align with strategic priorities — even when it is politically difficult.

Consider: is your team's current workload a reflection of deliberate strategic choice, or has it accumulated organically?

Circle your rating for this question

1 2 3 4 5

Rarely / never

Consistently / always

19

I connect the work of my team to the organisation's broader purpose and strategy in a way that makes the work feel meaningful.

Consider: does your team understand how their daily work contributes to something larger? Have you told them recently?

Circle your rating for this question

1 2 3 4 5

Rarely / never

Consistently / always

20

I build relationships with peers, stakeholders, and leaders outside my immediate area to stay informed and to extend my team's influence.

Consider: who outside your direct function do you invest in regularly — not for a specific project, but for the relationship itself?

Circle your rating for this question

1 2 3 4 5

Rarely / never

Consistently / always

Scoring Guide

Add your scores · Interpret your results · Identify development priorities

Total your scores for each competency (add the five ratings). Then total all four competency scores for your overall score out of 100.

Competency	Questions	Max Score	Your Score	Individual Ratings
Communication	1 – 5	25	___ / 25	Q1:___ Q2:___ Q3:___ Q4:___ Q5:___
Decision-Making	6 – 10	25	___ / 25	Q6:___ Q7:___ Q8:___ Q9:___ Q10:___
Team Development	11 – 15	25	___ / 25	Q11:___ Q12:___ Q13:___ Q14:___ Q15:___
Strategic Thinking	16 – 20	25	___ / 25	Q16:___ Q17:___ Q18:___ Q19:___ Q20:___
			___ / 100	Sum of all four competency scores

Competency Score Interpretation

Applies to each of the four competency scores (out of 25)

Score	Level	What it suggests	Development focus
21 – 25	Strength	This is a consistent strength. You demonstrate these behaviours reliably across contexts.	Build on this — look for opportunities to coach others in this area or apply it to higher-complexity situations.
14 – 20	Developing	You demonstrate these behaviours in many situations but not yet consistently.	Identify the 1–2 questions where you rated yourself lowest. Focus development effort there first.
5 – 13	Growth Area	This competency has significant room for development. Your current practice is inconsistent.	Consider this a priority development area. Seek feedback from others and build a specific action plan.

Overall Score Interpretation

Your total score out of 100

85–100 Highly Effective Leader

You demonstrate strong leadership behaviours consistently across all four competency areas. Your scores suggest you are applying these practices reliably in your day-to-day leadership.

Development focus: *Sustain and deepen: identify your lowest-scoring individual questions and use them as edge-cases for continued growth. Consider how you can develop these capabilities in others.*

65–84 Effective Leader with Development Opportunities

You demonstrate solid leadership behaviours across most areas. You have clear strengths and identifiable areas where your practice is less consistent.

Development focus: Focus on the competency where your score is lowest. Within that competency, work on the 1–2 specific questions where you rated yourself 2 or 3. Targeted focus here will have the highest impact.

45–64 Emerging Leader — Structured Development Recommended

Your leadership practice is developing. There are meaningful gaps between how you lead and how you would like to lead — or need to lead — in your current role.

Development focus: Do not try to work on everything at once. Choose one competency this quarter. Build a specific plan with your manager or coach. Use the reflection prompts on the next page.

20–44 Foundation Stage — Support and Development Required

Your scores suggest significant development is needed across multiple competency areas. This is not unusual for leaders early in their journey or in a new, more senior role.

Development focus: Seek structured support — a coach, mentor, or leadership development programme. Share these results with your manager or HR. Trying to self-develop across all areas simultaneously is unlikely to be effective.

IMPORTANT NOTE ON SELF-ASSESSMENT

Self-assessment scores are a starting point for reflection — not a definitive measure of your leadership effectiveness. Research consistently shows that leaders rate themselves higher than their teams rate them on most competencies. After completing this assessment, consider sharing the questions with one or two trusted colleagues and asking them to rate you. The gap between how you see yourself and how others see you is where the most valuable development insight lives.

Reflection — Your Strengths

Look at the competency where you scored highest. Within that competency, identify the two questions where you rated yourself 4 or 5.

Which specific leadership behaviours are you most proud of, based on your scores?

Be specific — name the behaviour, not just the competency. 'I communicate clearly' is less useful than 'I give feedback promptly and name the specific behaviour I am addressing.'

How do you currently use these strengths — and where could you apply them more deliberately?

Strengths that are not actively deployed do not compound. Consider where underusing this strength is costing you or your team.

Reflection — Your Priority Development Area

Look at the competency where you scored lowest. Within that competency, identify the single question where you rated yourself lowest.

Describe a specific recent situation where this leadership gap had a real cost — for you, your team, or your results.

Vague answers ('I could communicate better') produce vague plans. Name the situation: who was involved, what happened, what would have been different if you had led differently.

What belief or habit is most likely getting in the way of this behaviour?

Leadership gaps are rarely about knowledge — they are usually about habit, belief, or fear. What is the story you tell yourself that makes the current behaviour feel easier than the alternative?

What is one specific behaviour change you could make in the next 30 days that would address this gap?

The more specific the better. 'I will listen more' is not specific enough. 'I will not speak first in team meetings this month — I will ask a question instead' is actionable.

Reflection — Feedback and Blind Spots

Consider the gap between your self-perception and how others might see you.

Which of your ratings do you feel least confident about? Where might you be overrating or underrating yourself?

Identify 2–3 questions where your honest answer is 'I am not sure' or 'it depends'. These are the areas where external feedback would be most valuable.

Who in your life — at work or outside — could give you the most honest feedback on your leadership? What would you ask them?

The most valuable feedback comes from people who have seen you lead under pressure, in conflict, or when things were not going well. Name the person and write the specific question you would ask.

Reflection — Your 90-Day Commitment

A self-assessment that does not lead to action is just a number. Use this space to make a specific commitment.

What is the single most important leadership behaviour you commit to practising more consistently over the next 90 days?

Write it as a specific, observable behaviour — something a colleague could observe and confirm. Not 'be a better listener' but 'give people my full attention in 1:1s and not look at my phone.'

How will you know you are making progress? What will you notice — in yourself and in others?

Progress in leadership is often visible in how others respond to you before you feel it yourself. What signals would tell you that the change is taking hold?

Who will you share this commitment with — and how will you review your progress?

Commitments shared with another person are significantly more likely to be kept. Name the person and the date of your next review conversation.
